

Question 2

Introduction

I have been watching Counter-Strike: Global Offensive (CS:GO) for a long time. I enjoy watching Douyu TV commentator "MachineWJQ", and I also have great respect for top players like ZywOo, simple and donk. In the 2014 DreamHack Winter Fnatic vs LDLC competition, the notorious "olofboost" stood out while praising its ingenious gameplay. This essay uses three scholarly papers to analyze the event video. It will contextualize the increase in competitive offenses, define it using the terms "glitch" and "metagame," analyze community responses using theories of cheating perception, and evaluate its effect on spectating aesthetics ("legibility"). According to the analysis, the incident sparked the development of esports.

Rule-breaking in CS:GO

To understand the "olofboost", we first need to look at other kinds of rule-breaking in CS:GO. There is a wide range of unfair actions. At one end, there are very clear violations. This includes players "cheating to win" with outside software, which Johnson & Abarbanel (2022, p. 1704) identify as a primary concern among spectators, like when French star KQLY got a VAC ban right before the 2014 DreamHack Winter Major. It also includes "cheating to lose" by fixing matches (Johnson & Abarbanel, 2022, p. 1704), like the 2014 iBUYPOWER scandal where a top team threw a game for betting money. Perhaps the most shocking example of explicit cheating was the 2018 case of Forsaken (OpTic India), who was caught by a referee using an aimbot during a live tournament. The public footage of him attempting to delete the cheat file (word.exe) while being inspected became an iconic image of disgrace, and the incident triggered a catastrophic collapse of the entire Indian CS:GO environment. Cheating methods have also become more high-tech; in September 2025, a Chinese player "somebody" (former TyLoo and RA player) was accused of using a "soft router" to run a radar cheat. Rule-breaking also involves outside things. For example, in a match between FURIA and Team Falcons, the live crowd was accused of "spectator cheating" when their cheers gave away the location of a player hidden in a smoke grenade to FURIA's opponent, kyxsan. The issue can even be about hardware. In a CS2 match, Heroic had to give up a map win to NIP because a player used the Razer keyboard's "Snap Tap" exclusive feature, which was ruled as an illegal script. All these cases, from software and match-fixing to audiences and hardware, are testing the rules of e-sports. All of them violate fair

competition and are far from what Bainbridge & Bainbridge (2007, p. 61) called "creative use of software errors" (which may define other marginal cases).

The 2020 Coaching Bug

The scandal is one example. It's about the audience system. In this case, the coach used "glitches" during the game to obtain unfair information. Bainbridge & Bainbridge (2007, p. 62) stated that glitch is "a software error, either a programming error or a design defect." Although they didn't use it. The ESports Integrity Commission (ESIC) has banned some famous coaches, including mechanoGun of Hard Legion, zews of MIBR, and HUNDEN of Hero Team with star players like CadiaN. Bainbridge & Bainbridge (2007, p. 62) stated that "minor glitch" can turn into "cheating", which means "mastering the skills of the game by bypassing the official game rules". People in the community have different opinions. Some people blame the coach, while others blame those who organize the games or the "bad system" of the games. This helps us understand what the "olofboost" is. It wasn't a secret trick like the coaching bug. It was a very public use of a glitch in a big match, which made everyone think about the line between smart plays and cheating, or "innovation" and breaking the rules (Bainbridge & Bainbridge, 2007, p. 73).

Defining the "Olofboost"

The "olofboost" itself was a clever use of a hidden game flaw. As the video shows, Fnatic's players worked together to boost their teammate (27:00), olofmeister, to a spot that should be unreachable. This spot is a perfect example of a "glitch". It happens when the game's "display model and its world model" do not match (Bainbridge & Bainbridge, 2007, p. 64). Fnatic exploited this by using what was essentially an "air wall" that shouldn't have existed: a few invisible pixels on the wall that were solid enough to stand on (28:51). The video clearly shows olofmeister on this spot (29:26), giving him a view that the game's designers never planned. This was more than just playing the game; it was an act of "metagame". According to Bainbridge & Bainbridge (2007, p. 72), "victory is having the power to define the nature and rules of the game" in a "metagame. Fnatic altered the Overpass map's rules on their own by utilizing this "glitch." This resulted in an extremely dramatic match, with Fnatic using their "Olofboost" when LDLC had a commanding 13-3 lead (28:40). LDLC lost the game 13-16 (54:09) as their momentum became unstoppable. The new plan worked right away. The video shows olofmeister getting an easy kill from this spot (29:47) which shocks an LDLC player named "Smithzz" (29:51). The commentators were excited at first, but then they lost their way. Semmler said, "You

gotta be kidding me." (29:55) shows how surprised everyone was.

Community and Moral Judgement

The CS:GO community reacted very negatively. The "olofboost" created a big argument: was it against the rules, or just unfair? At the time, there was no specific rule against this boost. On the contrary, Fnatic exploited a game exploit to defeat LDLC and celebrated after the match (54:11). This put Fnatic in a gray area, so they could argue they did nothing wrong according to the "explicit" rules which are "formally stated and agreed to" (Bainbridge & Bainbridge, 2007, p. 74). But the community quickly and harshly decided it was a moral failure. That day, almost all online forums were talking about it, and criticizing Fnatic became a trend. People called Olofmeister "Boostmeister," and the whole team was criticized. This demonstrates what Johnson & Abarbanel (2022, p. 1707) characterize as an exceedingly "low tolerance" among fans for actions that compromise the integrity of a match. The commentators' voices went from excited to worried, which showed how they felt. When the LDLC players finally saw Olof's boosting (45:33), they asked for a timeout right away (45:48). On the other hand, Fnatic players didn't seem to care at all (47:35). LDLC can't go back in time for this semi-final, though. After the game, commentator Anders Blume said, "This isn't legal, you can't do this." He was making "moral judgments" based on the thoughts of the majority of people in the community, which went beyond the scope stipulated by the rules.

Rules vs. Ethics

This incident shows that morality and rules are not always consistent. Many people who have seen this think it is very stressful (Johnson & Abarbanel, 2022, p. 1709). Fnatic took the risk. When they did what they did, they thought they were doing the right thing. But people think they are right. Ferrari (2013, p. 11) refers to this as "the spirit of gameplay". If you have a good reason, people might allow you to break the rules. For instance, some fans feel sorry for the iBP players. This is because there is no salary and not much reward (Johnson & Abarbanel, 2022, p. 1710). On the other hand, Fnatic is a great team. A minor glitch helped them win a big game. People are really angry. This indicates that people are concerned about the authenticity of e-sports (Johnson & Abarbanel, 2022, p. 1711). Fans want "fair competition and genuine results" (McLaren, 2008; Johnson & Abarbanel, 2022, p. 1711). "olofboost" makes the result look fake. Public pressure also played a certain role. The officials discovered this loophole. They asked for another chance. Then, Fnatic decided to leave.

"Legibility"

Due to the influence of "olofboost", it is also very difficult to watch the game. This is a good way to think about the appearance of things. Ferrari (2013, p. 10) called it a "readability" problem, which makes it very difficult for people to see what is happening. You can see what's happening, but you can't understand the story or the game strategy. The players in the "LDLC" video seem to have no idea what to do. They have no idea where the bullets came from (31:33). This ruined the drama of CS:GO, which is based on smart positioning and fair fights. The match turned into a race to win at all costs, which was a purely "purposive" act because the "manner of achieving" the goal was not beautiful (Best, 1978, cited in Ferrari, 2013, p. 6). This is very different from another famous olofmeister moment I remember well: his "burning defuse" against Dignitas in 2014 on the same map, Overpass. In that play, he defused the bomb while standing in fire, dying just as he won the round. That was an act of bravery and skill within the game's normal, "explicit" rules (Bainbridge & Bainbridge, 2007, p. 74).

A Comparison

Ferrari (2013, p. 2) defines "Impressive play" as "performance that fascinates, transcending concerns of winning and losing". The "olofboost" was fascinating, but for all the wrong reasons. It lacked the "inner beauty connecting intention and execution" that knowledgeable fans love (Lowood, 2010, cited in Ferrari, 2013, p. 3), because it was based on an exploit that had no counter-play. But the "burning defuse" was a very good play. The developers and the community loved it. Valve even put a picture of a burning angel on the map to remember it. Valve's "memorial" for the "olofboost," on the other hand, was a "No climbing" sign hidden behind a truck that you could only see with cheat codes. One action was seen as heroic, while the other was seen as wrong, or a "transgression." Olofmeister himself is a good example of this difference. Despite the controversy of the "olofboost," it did not overshadow his incredible skill as a player. In 2015, the year after the boost, HLTV, a well-known esports site, named olofmeister the best player in the world. This means that many people knew how good he was. I like it when players do amazing things within the rules, like ZywOo does. I don't like it when they cheat. Fnatic lost, which showed that they knew they had made a mistake in the match. It broke the unspoken promise that players and fans had made to each other: the game had to be fair. Another unacceptable fact is that this event indirectly caused LDLC to end, which means that this Major-winning team is no longer a part of CS:GO history. After the

olofboost scandal, every member of LDLC joined EnVyUs. When Fnatic won the Majors, LDLC fell apart and I was so sad.

Conclusion

Valve thus corrected the map. The organizers of the competition also stated that players cannot use minor glitches like "pixel Walk" to disrupt the game. These changes have enabled CS:GO to grow. They have made e-sports more professional by improving rules and ethics.

References

- Bainbridge, W. A., & Bainbridge, W. S. (2007). Creative uses of software errors: Glitches and cheats. *Social Science Computer Review*, 25(1), 61–77.
- Ferrari, S. (2013). eSport and the human body: Foundations for a popular aesthetics. *Proceedings of DiGRA 2013: DeFragging Game Studies*.
- Johnson, M. R., & Abarbanel, B. (2022). Ethical judgments of esports spectators regarding cheating in competition. *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies*, 28(6), 1699–1715.
- Swoier. (2014, November 29). *LDLC vs Fnatic on de_overpass @ Dreamhack Winter 2014 Quarter Finals (CS:GO LDLC vs Fnatic) Game 3* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fmKYwGhJ39k>